

CONSUMER'S GUIDE TO COMMUNICATING WITH PRECISION

Amazon's culture is peculiar in how we communicate. The six-page narrative, Working Backwards Process, Press Releases and Frequently Asked Questions are well documented. This paper explores principles of good communication at Amazon in day-to-day business scenarios, and describes commonly used frameworks and best practices for communicating with precision.

WHY WE NEED PRECISE COMMUNICATION

At Amazon, our Leadership Principles guide communication practices. Leaders at Amazon do not judge your answer, decision, or proposal to be "good" or "bad", "right" or "wrong". We hire smart people and we count on them to do the hard, diligent work so that their outputs are sound. What leaders do is evaluate how you got to your answer, decision, or proposal. They do this by examining the assumptions you started from, and the process you used to arrive at your answer. Precision communication is important because it facilitates this peculiar process of evaluation we use at Amazon. Here are some examples of how this is done:

- Communicating the right level of detail helps leaders stay connected to the details of the business and enables them to audit. (Dive Deep)
- Writing things down helps us to clarify the logic of our thinking, and as a result, we are able to test the quality of our work and make decisions on exact plans. (Deliver Results)
- Leaders' minds can be changed with facts. Communications written with literal, concise and relevant data enable leaders to examine their own thinking, and can help them overrule their strongest convictions. (Earns Trust of Others, Are right a Lot)
- Sharing relevant information, with all the facts enables leaders to make the right decisions. (Are right a Lot)
- If a leader finds a flaw in one of your assumptions, or your process, then the usual action assigned is to change or correct the flawed assumption or process and then to redo the analysis. You then get back to the leader with a revised answer, decision, or proposal, usually with a very quick turnaround. (Are right a Lot, Bias for Action)
- Challenging and engaging in direct conversation and detail supports exploring ideas fully. (Have Backbone, Disagree and Commit)
- Questions from leaders are precise. Sometimes the "question" is as simple as a "?" mark. An effective response requires communicators to dive deep to answer the question- Is it true? If it is true, do we understand why? What is the plan to get it fixed? What is the root cause? How can we fix the root cause? (Dive Deep)
- Proactive communication about issues helps maintain a nimble culture where we can demonstrate bias for action. (Bias for Action)
- Respect is gained by communicating with the right level of detail, accuracy, timeliness and conviction which enables earning the trust of others. (Earns Trust of Others)

PRINCIPLES FOR COMMUNICATION

Clear communication implies clear thinking, and conversely, confusing communication implies confused thinking. The following general principles of communication will help you write and speak with clarity and precision. These principles can be broadly applied in all communication, but we find them useful in day to day business practices such as: interview debriefs, directs meetings, writing and presenting a paper, executive escalations and regular written communications.

Start with Why: Start with what you are trying to achieve. It should be a succinct summary that captures the purpose of the communication. This provides the context for the recipient that is needed to understand and respond to your communication.

Communicate with Concision: Try to write and say what you intend to say in 5 words vs 50. Be literal. It is assumed that everything you include in a communication is intentional, so it is important to pay attention to the details.

CONSUMER'S GUIDE TO COMMUNICATING WITH PRECISION

Support Communication with Data: At Amazon, we believe anything that can be measured should be measured; therefore, we expect that all communications should be backed with data. Where data doesn't exist, it should be presented as an idea or hypothesis.

Communicate Proactively: Proactively bring *relevant* issues to the awareness of leaders. Judge your timing. If you have an issue that is not relevant to the entire room participating in the current discussion or on a given email string, wait and bring it up in a more relevant setting/different email string.

Resolve and Communicate the Root Cause: Communicate resolutions that not only address the issue, but also to resolve the underlying problem that caused the defect.

Write in Narrative, and then Edit: Communications should be written in narrative form. Data and charts can be included in the appendix that supports the story. After writing out an initial paragraph/email, etc., read the first sentence and determine whether or not it communicates a concise point to the readers.

Show up Confidently: Be present and position yourself as an owner and a leader with deep knowledge of your subject. Be careful not to be over-confident, however, in areas you are not an expert.

Understand the Situation: Understand the audience; demonstrate the ability to correctly assess what type of communication is needed and react accordingly.

Listen Effectively: Understands the value of listening to others. Probes to understand and confirms understanding of what is heard.

GENERAL GUIDE FOR COMMUNICATING WITH PRECISION

Some of what we've learned about communication at other companies and at school – including some elements that could be considered “conventional wisdom” – may not apply at Amazon. Amazon is peculiar in the way we communicate and there are many tips that can help with communicating successfully in this environment. The following is a collection of general tips that have been found useful in day to day business scenarios.

1. **Define the question/decision that is being asked:** Don't jump into the solution before framing the problem. The audience needs to understand the situation in order to assess if you have taken the correct course of action.
2. **Determine the timeframe that the question needs to be answered:** Take the time to understand what it will take to address the situation. Do you need development resources to get to the root cause? Is your answer dependent on an external party? A complete answer that takes three days to achieve is better than an incomplete response written in an hour. If a complete answer will take more than a day, communicate your timeline to keep everyone informed.
3. **Answer the question that was asked:** If you are asked a question – answer the question asked. If you don't understand the question, ask for clarification then extrapolate if needed. If you don't know the answer, say “I don't know” instead of guessing. Answer “who” questions with a name. Answer “when” questions with a date.
4. **Anticipate other questions that this question will generate:** Looking around corners is an important thought process at Amazon and you should think about the next question that will be generated by your response. Common follow questions include: “How many customers were impacted?”, “When will the root cause be fixed?”, “Has a Cause of Error been completed?” Strong answers will ensure the next question is answered as well.
5. **Avoid hyperbole- literal language is preferred:** “32.4% YoY growth” is preferred over “huge growth”; “107K or 5.9% of SnS customers were impacted” is preferred over “many SnS customers were impacted”.
6. **Assume zero context, but share only what is appropriate:** Step back from your understanding of the issue and include enough information to avoid multiple follow up questions about the background of the issue.
7. **Follow English 101:** Appendix A contains tips for communicating with a global audience

Common pitfalls:

1. Not actively listening to the discussion in order to address the right topic
2. Failing to follow-up with open issues or providing incomplete follow-up
3. Faking the answer - being overconfident when you don't have all the details
4. Responding with the answer you prepared instead of answering the question that was asked
5. Not thinking through all the scenarios
6. Making statements of fact that aren't supported by data
7. Over or under sharing context/detail
8. Generalizing or using jargon, slang, pompous language
9. Making excessive use of adjectives and adverbs

APPENDIX A- ENGLISH 101

SUMMARY – TIPS FOR REVIEWING YOUR WRITING

- Use more formal, "standard" language and, depending on the English proficiency level of your international participants, use short "core" expressions.
- Avoid verbiage; favor brief, uncomplicated sentences.
- Cover one point at a time.
- Avoid mixing topics within the same paragraph.
- Clarify and rephrase important statements to make sure you have been understood.
- Eliminate slang.
- Avoid, or explain idioms and specialized vocabulary.
- Avoid, or explain jargon and abbreviations.
- Carefully consider your use of active and passive voices. In general, give preference to the active voice.

USE STANDARD ENGLISH (AVOID IDIOMS)

Use "standard" English rather than slang or idiomatic expressions whenever possible.

Be aware of your native speaker's natural tendency to use idiomatic expressions, slang, and specialized vocabulary.

Every language has phrases and expressions that cannot be understood literally. Generally, these expressions tend to be culture specific. So, even if a non-native speaker understands the meaning of all the words in such a phrase and they understand the grammar completely, the total meaning of the phrase may still be confusing.

For example: "To *get the inside track*" = To get the advantage over someone because of special connections, knowledge or favoritism.

English has many thousands of such idiomatic expressions. When writing for an international audience with varying degrees of English proficiency, the effective writer should attempt to use "standard", rather than idiomatic English.

Standard English can be defined as *descriptive*, not *figurative*. Things are described as they are, not compared to others that are similar to them.

Consider the following examples:

"front-end" direction, intervention	opening, preliminary, initial
"Trouble shoot"	solve problems
"A take on something"	an opinion on something
"Clear cut"	obvious
"laser focus"	a detailed focus, or analysis
"have a close call"	a narrow escape from (something dangerous)
"in left field"	not pertinent, not relevant to the central issue
"Let's play ball"	to begin something

CONSIDER PARAGRAPH UNITY

A paragraph is a group of sentences that develops one main idea.

A unified paragraph focuses on one key idea and develops. The key idea is stated in the *topic sentence*, which provides direction to the paragraph just as a thesis sentence provides direction to an entire essay.

Topic sentences, which serve to state the main idea of the paragraph, can be placed at the beginning, middle or end of a paragraph. They are most commonly highlighted at the beginning. All other sentences in the paragraph should support and build on the topic sentence.

(For more definition, examples, and some exercises, refer to any writer's handbook of style and grammar)

CONSIDER SENTENCE STRUCTURE

Keep your sentences as short and simple as possible. This will greatly enhance reading speed and comprehension for non-native speakers of English with low or intermediate levels of proficiency.

(Reference a writer's handbook of style and grammar for a review of sentence construction that includes examples and exercises).

CHECK FOR PARALLEL STRUCTURES IN LISTS:

Begin all bulleted lists with a parallel grammatical structure as in:

- Modify (verb) the audit plan...
- Communicate (verb) the identified risk factors...
- Discuss (verb) the identified risk...
- Determine (verb) if the presence of risk factors requires...

Avoid non-parallel lists such as:

- Test (verb) specific risk controls
- An emphasis (noun) on client analysis
- Focusing (gerund) on business risks.

(For additional examples and exercises reference a writer's handbook of style and grammar).

AVOID VERBIAGE (UNINTELLIGIBLE, POMPOUS LANGUAGE)

Besides avoiding jargon, slang and idiomatic expressions, avoid verbiage: unintelligible, pompous language. Verbiage may sound more important and official, but rarely states the message clearly, especially for non-native speakers of English!

Some examples to avoid and follow would be:

<u>Verbiage</u>	<u>Plain English</u>
At this juncture, the aforementioned procedures should be utilized.	The plan we discussed should be used now.
We should implement operational capabilities in systematic increments.	We should implement the project step-by-step.
Also eliminate modifiers such as "basically", "nearly", "hardly".	

CONSUMER'S GUIDE TO COMMUNICATING WITH PRECISION

AVOID WORDINESS

Effective professional writing is characterized by brevity. The concise writer avoids roundabout phrases in favor of direct, concise expressions. Consider the following examples:

<u>Roundabout/Wordy</u>	<u>Concise expression</u>
A majority of	Most (Even better, give an exact number)
A downward adjustment	A cut, decrease
Be of assistance to	Help, assist
In view of the fact that	Because
Due to the fact that	Because
Is situated in	Is in
In reference to	On, about
Provided that	If

AVOID REDUNDANCY

A redundancy is a phrase that says the same thing twice: it contains obvious repetition of an idea ("each and every"). Such repetition is pointless, wordy and distracting.

Consider the following and the suggested revisions.

REDUNDANT

THERE ARE *MANY IN NUMBER* WHO CONSIDER THE TOTAL UNDERSTANDING OF *BASIC FUNDAMENTALS* A *GOOD ASSET*.

IT IS *ABSOLUTELY ESSENTIAL* TO COMPLETELY ELIMINATE *BIGOTRY AND PREJUDICE*

DIRECT

MANY CONSIDER THE UNDERSTANDING OF BASICS AND ASSET.

BIGOTRY MUST BE ELIMINATED.

REFLECT ON THE CHOICE OF ACTIVE OR PASSIVE CONSTRUCTIONS

Verbs have two "voices": active and passive.

In an active-voice expression the subject of the sentence performs the action stated by the verb. Generally, the active voice suggests immediacy and emphasizes the subject:

Mr. Jones *conducts* the tours.

The president *presented* the budget

The new price *will increase* our profit.

Passive voice tends to be wordy (there are at least two parts to the verb) The passive voice may bury your idea in a sluggish sentence. In passive expressions, the subject is acted upon:

The tours *are conducted by* Mr. Jones

The budget *was presented by* the president.

Our profit *will be increased by* the new price.

Rule of thumb:

Edit your writing to determine which voice permits your desired emphasis in the fewest number of words.

CONSUMER'S GUIDE TO COMMUNICATING WITH PRECISION

For example:

The secretary typed the report. (Emphasis on secretary)

The report was typed by the secretary. (Emphasis on report).